

The Pride of a Pathan

The festival of Id was **drawing near** and Alamat, the woodcutter, was **in a quandary**. His wife was demanding money to buy cloth to make new clothes for her children and herself and Alamat had no money and no **prospects** of getting any in the next few days.

As he was **strolling** down a road, **pondering** over his problem, he saw a traveller coming his way. The man was leading a donkey **laden** with **bales** of cloth.

Alamat's **pulse raced** with excitement. Here was the solution to his problem! Picking up three large stones he stood in the middle of the road and waited for the traveller to come nearer. When he did, he **flung** a stone at him. The stone hit the traveller on the shoulder and he **drew back in alarm**.

"Why are you attacking me?" he asked. "What harm have I done you?"

"You've done me no harm," said Alamat. "I am a **robber**. I want the cloth you're carrying."

"I've no mind to **resist** you," said the traveller. "If you want the cloth, take it." Alamat flung another stone at him and the man **staggered** backwards.

"I said, take it," **screamed** the man. "Why are you still **stoning** me!"

"Robbery has to be **accompanied** by violence," said the woodcutter. "Else, what difference would there be between me and a beggar? Among us Pathans, a beggar is lower than a dog."

He picked up another stone, and the traveller **fled, abandoning** his donkey.

Alamat lifted the load of clothes from the donkey's back and took it home where he threw it at his wife's feet.

"Make clothes for the children and yourself and all your relatives," he said. "There's enough for all."

Id came and went. One day, Alamat was shopping for beans in the market when he felt a heavy hand on his shoulder. He turned round and, **to his horror**, found himself face to face with the man he had recently robbed.

"What are you buying, brother?" asked the man.

"Beans," said Alamat.



"There's no need to buy beans here," said the man. "I've had a good harvest of beans and I'll give you as many bags as you want. Come to my house."

There were two **burly** men with him so Alamat could not refuse. When they arrived at his house, which was a **considerable** distance from the market, the man **called out** to his wife to bring **refreshments** for their guest.

Alamat **hardly** touched the food and drink set before him. He **wondered** what punishment was coming and **resolved** that if he survived, he would never commit a dishonest act again. Finally, he said to his host, "If you could give me the beans I'll pay you your price and be on my way."

The man loaded a **sack** of beans on Alamat's donkey and told him he could go.

"I do not want a whole sack," said Alamat, **cautiously**, wondering what the man was up to. "I have only a few coins..."

"I'm giving it in **charity**," said his host. "It's free."

"Free!" **roared** Alamat. "Do you think I'm a beggar! How dare you!"

He **strode** towards his donkey to fling the sack down when he felt the barrel of a gun pressed into his side.

"Get on your donkey and go," said his host. "Or I'll **blow** your head **off**!"

To be treated like a beggar was a great insult, but Alamat knew **resistance** was **futile**. The man was quite capable of shooting him. **Swallowing his pride**, he got on his donkey and rode away.

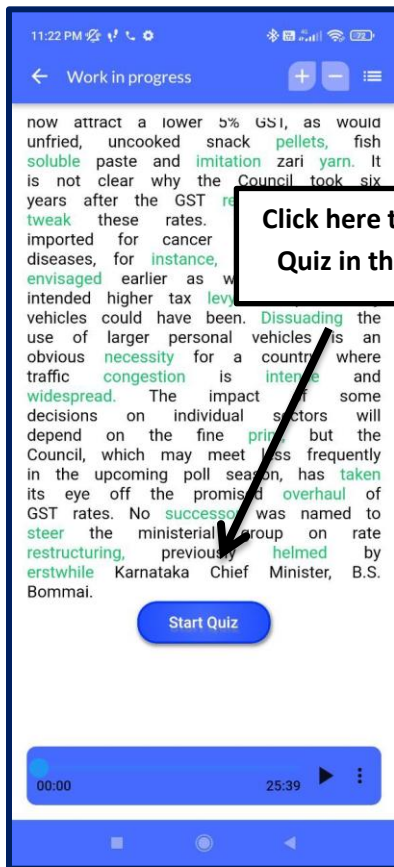
But from then on, he began delivering a load of wood to the man's house once each month. He did this **religiously** for ten years till one day the man told him he had got enough, which Alamat took to mean that he had paid in full for the cloth and the beans. He saluted the man, turned his donkey around and rode away, his **head held high**. No one could call him a beggar now.

Vocabulary

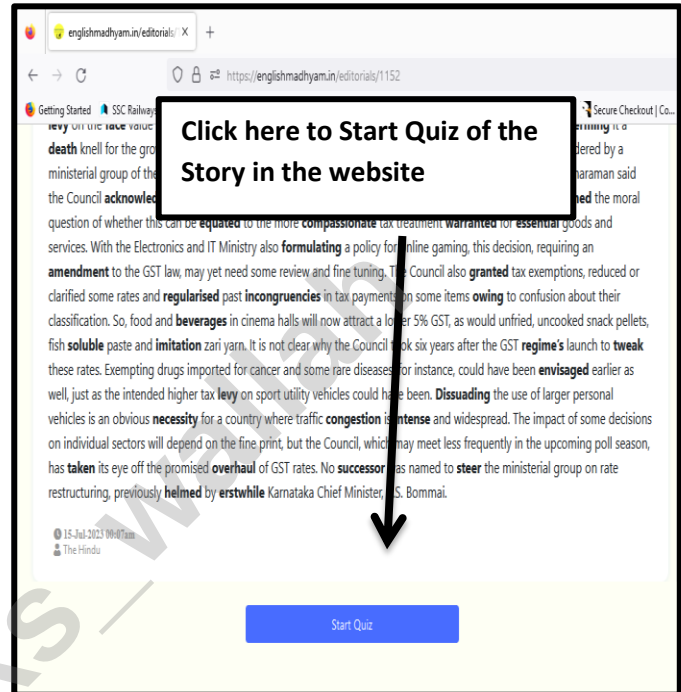
1. **Pride** (noun) – Self-respect, dignity, honor, ego, self-esteem गर्व
2. **Draw near** (phrase) – Approach, come close, near, advance, move closer पास आना
3. **In a quandary** (phrase) – Confused, puzzled, uncertain, in dilemma, in a fix उलझन में
4. **Prospect** (noun) – Possibility, chance, likelihood, opportunity, outlook संभावना
5. **Stroll** (verb) – Walk, saunter, amble, wander, ramble टहलना
6. **Ponder** (verb) – Think, consider, contemplate, reflect, deliberate विचार करना
7. **Laden** (with) (verb) – Loaded, burdened, piled, filled, packed लदा हुआ
8. **Bale** (noun) – Bundle, package, parcel, pack, stack गठरी
9. **Pulse** (noun) – Heartbeat, throb, beat, rhythm, pulsation नाड़ी/धड़कन
10. **Race** (verb) – Rush, hurry, speed, sprint, hasten दौड़ना/तेज़ धड़कना
11. **Fling** (verb) – Throw, hurl, toss, cast, pitch फेंकना
12. **Draw back** (phrase) – Retreat, recoil, withdraw, pull back, step back पीछे हटना
13. **In alarm** (phrase) – In fear, with fright, in panic, with anxiety, in shock घबराहट में
14. **Robber** (noun) – Thief, bandit, mugger, burglar, looter डाकू/लुटेरा
15. **Resist** (verb) – Oppose, fight, withstand, defy, refuse विरोध करना
16. **Stagger** (verb) – Wobble, reel, sway, totter, stumble लड़खड़ाना
17. **Scream** (verb) – Shout, shriek, yell, cry out, screech चिल्लाना
18. **Stone** (verb) – Throw stones, pelt, bombard, hit with stones, attack with rocks पत्थर मारना
19. **Accompany** (verb) – Go with, escort, attend, join, partner साथ जाना
20. **Flee** (verb) – Run away, escape, bolt, abscond, take flight भाग जाना
21. **Abandon** (verb) – Leave, desert, forsake, discard, quit छोड़ देना
22. **To one's horror** (phrase) – To one's shock, to one's fear, to one's dismay, to one's surprise, with great fear किसी के भय के लिए
23. **Burly** (adjective) – Muscular, strong, hefty, brawny, sturdy ताकतवर/मजबूत

24. **Considerable** (adjective) – Significant, substantial, large, ample, notable
काफी/महत्वपूर्ण
25. **Call out** (phrasal verb) – Shout, summon, yell, announce, cry out
पुकारना
26. **Refreshment** (noun) – Snack, food, drink, light meal, sustenance
जलपान
27. **Hardly** (adverb) – Barely, scarcely, almost not, just, seldom
मुश्किल से
28. **Wonder** (verb) – Think, question, ponder, doubt, be curious
सोच में पड़ना
29. **Resolve** (verb) – Decide, determine, settle, conclude, make up one's mind
संकल्प लेना
30. **Sack** (noun) – Bag, pouch, sackful, tote, container
बोरी
31. **Charity** (noun) – Donation, generosity, alms, philanthropy, benevolence
दान
32. **Roar** (verb) – Shout loudly, yell, bellow, howl, thunder
गरजना
33. **Stride** (verb) – Walk confidently, march, pace, stalk, step
तेजी से चलना
34. **Blow off** (phrasal verb) – Shoot, fire, explode, blast, destroy
उड़ा देना
35. **Resistance** (noun) – Opposition, defiance, fight, struggle, refusal
विरोध
36. **Futile** (adjective) – Useless, pointless, ineffective, vain, fruitless
व्यर्थ
37. **Swallow one's pride** (phrase) – Humble oneself, accept humiliation, concede, give in, relent
अपनी शान छोड़ना
38. **Religiously** (adverb) – Faithfully, regularly, devotedly, diligently, consistently
नियमित रूप से
39. **Head held high** (phrase) – With pride, confidently, proudly, with dignity, with honour
सिर ऊँचा करके

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